

CHAPTER 3 km — requested variables that are not directly available

Date: 2026-09-17 · **Scope:** the variable list requested for the CHAPTER regional reanalysis (atmosphere, static, land-surface, ocean waves, sea ice, surface ocean). This note answers one question: of the variables you asked for, which ones can we actually put in the GRIB archive, which ones we can obtain by some other route, and which ones are simply not in the data. It is meant to be read before we commit to a re-conversion of the whole archive, because that re-conversion costs several days of data transfer and has to be done only once. Everything below was verified against the actual files, not against documentation: model configuration read from the wrfout global attributes, and every field checked for real values on independent timesteps in summer 2019, summer 2024 (00/06/12/13/14/18/23 UTC) and March 2024, so that fields which exist in the file but are identically zero are not mistaken for usable data. Accumulated fields were additionally checked for monotonicity within a run, and every ECMWF parameter identifier was round-tripped through the GRIB encoder to confirm name and units. Companion documents: CHAPTER_VARIABLES.md is the reference for what the archive does contain, and CHAPTER_KNOWN_PROPERTIES.md collects the measured properties and biases of the variables we *do* provide — including the numbers behind several of the caveats in §5 below.

1. Summary

requested block	verdict
Atmosphere, surface (24 variables + wind shear)	22 of 24 delivered , plus wind shear. Only the two gust components are missing, and they are excluded by decision (see §4)
Atmosphere, pressure levels (9 variables × 13 levels)	all delivered , plus both vertical-velocity forms (w in Pa/s and w_z in m/s) and three extra ERA5 fields: cloud fraction cc , rain $crwc$ and snow $cswc$ water content
TKE at 3 height levels	not available — the model does not compute it
Static: orography	delivered
Static: land-use / land-cover	dominant category only, never fractions — the file that holds the fractions no longer exists (see §4)
Land-surface	delivered as the subset that exists, with ERA5 names — now including the complete radiation budget, runoff, snow cover, snow temperature, albedo, surface stress and the high/low vegetation split
Ocean waves (SWH, period, direction, wave-dependent C_d)	not available — no wave model
Sea ice	concentration delivered ; thickness, snow on ice, ice temperature and albedo not available
Surface ocean (SSH, currents, SST)	SST delivered ; SSH and currents not available

2. Why: how the archive is produced

The archive is produced from hourly WRF 4.1.1 output (domain d02, Mercator, 1641×1353 points at 3 km, 49 vertical levels). The relevant configuration is identical across all periods we checked (2019, March 2024, July 2024):

option	value	consequence for this list
BL_PBL_PHYSICS	1 (YSU)	non-local scheme: no prognostic TKE . PBLH was also not written out
KM_OPT	4	no prognostic turbulent kinetic energy array either
SF_OCEAN_PHYSICS	0	the ocean is not simulated : no currents, no sea surface height, no mixed layer
(no wave model)	—	no wave fields of any kind, and therefore no wave-dependent drag coefficient
SST_UPDATE	0	SST is constant within each 24 h run , re-initialised at every daily run
CU_PHYSICS	0	convection-permitting: RAINC is identically zero, so total precipitation is complete in RAINNC
MP_PHYSICS	6 (WSM6)	cloud, rain, ice, snow and graupel are available; no hail category
ICLOUD	1 (Xu-Randall)	cloud fraction is continuous , not a 0/1 flag — see §5
SF_SURFACE_PHYSICS	3 (RUC)	6 soil levels at 0, 5, 20, 40, 160, 300 cm (ERA5 uses 4 layers)
SF_LAKE_PHYSICS, SF_URBAN_PHYSICS	0, 0	no lake model, no urban canopy

A separate point worth making explicitly: some fields are present in the files but are **identically zero on every timestep we sampled**, and are therefore not usable. These are ACHFX, ACLHF, ACGRDFLX, NOAHRES, SSTSK, SST_INPUT, SWNORM, ACSNOW, HAILNC, RAINC, RAINSH, PREC_ACC_C, and the downward longwave at the top of the atmosphere. None of them will be written to the GRIB files.

3. Variables we can obtain by another route

These are not in the model output, but there is a defensible way to get them. None of them is implemented: each needs a decision first. Items that appeared here in previous versions have moved: **surface albedo is now delivered** (`al`, the snow-free background, and `fa1`, the actual all-sky ratio), and **fractional land cover is now delivered too** — the static file `geo_em.d02`, recorded here as irrecoverable, was obtained from LRZ on 2026-09-18 and is the run's own (its land use agrees with the model's dominant category on 100.00 % of points once the lake recode is excluded). It brought `cvl`, `cvh`, `tv1`, `tvh`, `s1t`, `cl` and `d1`.

variable	route	confidence	cost
Sea-ice surface temperature	Use the skin temperature we already derive, restricted to points where sea-ice concentration > 0	Medium. It is a radiative skin temperature, consistent with the model's own longwave emission, but not a dedicated ice-surface temperature	Free
Drag coefficient without wave effect	From the model's own roughness length: $C_d = (\kappa / \ln(10/z_0))^2$	Exact — this is precisely the drag the simulation used (Charnock, no wave coupling)	Free
Planetary boundary layer height	Bulk Richardson number on the virtual potential temperature profile; all required fields are present	Reasonable — the same class of diagnostic the model itself would apply	Free

4. Variables we cannot provide

variable	why	the only way to get it
10efg, 10nfg (eastward / northward gust components)	Only a gust <i>magnitude</i> proxy exists (see §5), and it is the maximum of the resolved wind, not a gust scheme. Their direction would have to be assumed equal to the mean wind, at an instant that does not even coincide with the maximum	Decomposing the magnitude along the 10 m wind is possible and cheap, but it was judged too weak to publish under ERA5 names, so it was decided not to produce them
TKE (at any level)	The PBL scheme is YSU, which is non-local and carries no turbulent kinetic energy; the diffusion option does not produce one either. The field does not exist, at any height	Re-run WRF with a TKE-carrying PBL scheme (MYNN or MYJ). A similarity-theory estimate would need boundary-layer height <i>and</i> surface heat flux, both themselves missing, so the errors compound: it would look plausible but would not be consistent with the simulation
Significant wave height, mean wave period, wave direction	No wave model was coupled to the atmosphere	A wave model run, or an external wave reanalysis (ERA5 waves at ~31 km) — which loses exactly the coastal detail that motivates a 3 km product
Drag coefficient including wave effect	Same reason: the surface exchange used Charnock roughness with no sea state	As above. The wave-free drag coefficient <i>is</i> available (§3)

variable	why	the only way to get it
Sea surface height, ocean currents (u, v)	The ocean is not simulated	An ocean reanalysis (e.g. CMEMS), regridded
Sea-ice thickness, snow thickness on sea ice	Not simulated. Sea ice enters only as a concentration boundary field	An external sea-ice product
Sea-ice albedo as a prognostic ice property	Not simulated	Approximable radiatively (§3), but not as an ice-model variable
Snowmelt	The field exists (ACSNOM) but is not a monotone accumulator : individual points drop back to zero within a single run (measured -7.26 mm against 00 UTC on 2024-07-01), so it cannot be referred to 00 UTC the way the other accumulations are. Published under the ERA5 name it would be wrong	Would need the melt diagnosed per timestep inside the model
Surface sensible and latent heat flux	The instantaneous fields were not written out, and the accumulated ones are identically zero in every file we checked	Partially reconstructable from the surface energy budget, but the ground heat flux is also missing, leaving two unknowns in one equation. Best treated as unavailable
Skin temperature as a model variable	TSK was not written out	We already provide skt, obtained by inverting the upward longwave flux (see §5)

Dropped on 2026-09-17 and **reinstated on 2026-09-18**, once the objection had an answer:

Variable	Why it was dropped	Why it is now published
Soil moisture and soil temperature (swvl1-4, stl1-4)	The scheme carries point values at 0, 5, 20, 40, 160 and 300 cm; ERA5's four layers are averages over 0-7, 7-28, 28-100 and 100-289 cm	The objection was against <i>relabelling</i> the point values, and it stands. But they can be integrated : the scheme is a level scheme with a linear profile between nodes, and ERA5's whole column lies inside those nodes (289 cm is above the deepest, 0 cm is the first), so each layer is the exact integral and nothing is extrapolated

Variable	Why it was dropped	Why it is now published
Vegetation and soil type (tv1, tvh, slt)	The categories are WRF's MODIS-IGBP and STATSGO ones, while those paramIds carry ECMWF's own code tables	slt is no longer a translation at all: ECMWF's seven types are <i>defined</i> by clay/sand thresholds, and the recovered static file carries clay and sand fractions, so the definition is applied directly. tv1/tvh do use a table, published in full in CHAPTER_VARIABLES.pdf §8; every row is a semantic identity, and the one question MODIS cannot answer (evergreen vs deciduous shrubs) is left missing rather than guessed
Vegetation cover (cv1, cvh)	They rested on one dominant category per cell, while ERA5 lets low and high vegetation coexist	The recovered static file has the fractional cover, so they are simple sums over the low and high classes — the same quantity ERA5 means. This was the right objection: 17.9 % of land cells carry both above 5 %, and the dominant category holds only 90.1 % of a cell on average

Still not published:

Variable	Why
lai_lv, lai_hv	The model carries a single LAI per cell; ERA5 wants one per vegetation class, defined per unit of vegetated area. Any split between the two would be our assumption. The model's own LAI can be delivered under its own name if wanted
anor, isor	The static file carries the Kim-Arakawa asymmetry and effective-length parameters. ECMWF's angle and anisotropy come from the eigenstructure of the terrain-gradient covariance: related, not the same, and the difference does not fit in one line

If either is needed, say so: the underlying WRF fields exist and can be delivered under their own names (LAI, VEGFRA, 0A1-4, 0L1-4), where nothing is claimed about ERA5 equivalence.

5. Caveats on the variables we *do* provide

These matter for correct use and should be read together with the variable list.

- **Cloud cover is fractional.** An earlier draft of this note said the model's cloud fraction was binary; that was wrong, and the correction is in our favour. The scheme is Xu-Randall and the field is genuinely continuous: over a 500 × 600 sub-domain only 18-22 % of cloudy points sit exactly at 1, the rest spread across the whole 0-1 range. Total, high, medium and low cloud cover are maximum-random overlaps of that field, and the cloud fraction is also delivered

per pressure level as cc.

- **SST is constant within each day.** Each daily run is initialised with a fixed sea surface temperature and does not update it. The field therefore has a daily, not hourly, time resolution.
- **Skin temperature is derived, not modelled.** TSK was not written out, so it is obtained by inverting the upward longwave flux, $LWUPB = \epsilon \sigma T^4 + (1-\epsilon) LWDN$, with the emissivity of the dominant land-use category (VEGPARM.TBL, 0.88 urban to 0.98 water). It is exact where the answer is known — over open water the model's skin temperature is the SST and the inversion recovers it to 0.005 K — and it matches the 0 cm soil level to under 1 K RMSE on snow-free land. Over snow the emissivity the scheme actually used cannot be reconstructed: about 0.8 K of residual uncertainty there.
- **The slope of orography is the resolved one.** ERA5's `slo` is a sub-grid parameter of the form-drag scheme; what we write is the slope of the resolved 3 km terrain. (`sdor` is instead a genuine sub-grid standard deviation, computed by the pre-processor.)
- **Water contents are specific, not mixing ratios.** WRF carries mixing ratios, per kg of dry air; `clwc`, `ciwc`, `crwc`, `cswc` and the column integrals are converted to specific contents, per kg of moist air, as their ECMWF definitions require (a 0.8 % correction in the median).
- **Convective inhibition is not defined everywhere.** By construction it is only computed where CAPE exceeds 100 J/kg, and CAPE itself is undefined at the few percent of points with no equilibrium level. We write **zero** at those points rather than a missing value, so that the fields stay dense; zero is also the physically correct reading (no inhibition, no available energy). If you would rather have them flagged as missing, say so now.
- **CAPE and CIN are most-unstable**, computed from the 500 m deep parcel with the highest equivalent potential temperature in the lowest 3 km — not surface-based.
- **The gust field is not a gust parameterisation.** It is the maximum of the *resolved* 10 m wind speed over the output hour. It behaves like a gust and is the best proxy available, but it is not produced by a gust scheme.
- **The land/sea mask changes with the season.** Where sea ice forms, the model reclassifies the point as ice: the land mask, the vegetation and soil types and the background albedo all change there (2469 points on 20 March 2024, exactly the sea-ice points). These fields are therefore written in every hourly file and must not be treated as a single static field for the archive.
- **Surface stress is a diagnostic, not a model output.** The eastward and northward stresses are reconstructed as density $\times$ friction velocity squared, aligned with the 10 m wind. The friction velocity is the model's own, so this is the same similarity theory the simulation used, but the alignment with the mean wind is an assumption.
- **Snow temperature only exists where there is snow.** The field is the temperature at the top of the snow/soil column; away from snow it is simply a soil temperature, so it is written as missing there rather than published as a snow temperature that does not exist.
- **Albedo comes in two forms.** `al` is the snow-free climatological background the model was initialised with; `fal` is the actual ratio of upward to downward shortwave, which is what the simulation really used — but it is undefined at night and is written as missing below 50 W/m² of incoming shortwave.
- **Total runoff is almost entirely surface runoff.** The sub-surface component is active on only 0.06 % of the points in July and 0.5 % in March, so `ro` and `sro` differ over a very small fraction of the domain. Both are published because `ro` is the ERA5-canonical total.
- **There is no graupel field**, although the microphysics produces graupel and it is not negligible at 3 km (column integrals up to 27 kg/m²): ERA5 simply has no parameter for it. The graupel is included in total column water, but cannot be published separately under an ERA5 name.
- **Rainfall excludes snow and graupel, not hail.** The microphysics has no hail category, so rain is total precipitation minus snow minus graupel.

- **2 m dewpoint is now in kelvin.** The previous GRIB1 archive wrote it in degrees Celsius under a parameter that ECMWF defines in kelvin. If you read 2d from the old files, it needs +273.15.
 - **Accumulated fields are referred to 00 UTC of the same day,** not to the start of the model run. They are exactly zero at 00 UTC. In the GRIB files they carry a 0-to-H accumulation step with a 00 UTC reference time, so the validity time is the timestep itself. The 10 m wind maximum is the exception: it covers the preceding hour only, because the model resets it at every output.
 - **Geolocation is now exact to ~2 m.** The grid declares the spherical earth of radius 6370 km that WRF actually integrates on. The previous GRIB1 files could not express this and were off by up to ~1.1 km at the northern edge of the domain.
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6. What we need from you

The questions about the gust components and about TKE that appeared here previously have been settled: neither is produced. The one about the static `geo_em` file is also closed, but the other way round from what this document said last: the file **was** obtained from LRZ on 2026-09-18, and everything that depended on it is now delivered (§3, §4).

1. **The land-surface list.** The original proposal was lost. We deliver, under ERA5 names: soil moisture and soil temperature (**4 layers, as true ERA5 layer averages**), snow depth, density, cover and temperature, snowfall, surface, sub-surface and total runoff, skin reservoir content, **high and low vegetation cover and type, soil type, lake cover and depth**, friction velocity, surface roughness, the two surface albedos, the two components of surface stress, and the complete radiation budget (downward, net and clear-sky, at the surface and at the top of the atmosphere). Two items of the original list are **not** among them: ****leaf area index****, because the model carries one value per cell and ERA5 wants one per vegetation class (§4), and **snowmelt**, because the field exists but is not a monotone accumulator (§4). Please confirm or amend.
2. **Wind shear: which definition?** We currently deliver the bulk 10 m to 100 m shear. Any other definition (fixed layers, per pressure level, 0-6 km bulk) is a one-line change, but it has to be decided before the archive is re-converted.
3. **Vertical levels.** We deliver 13 pressure levels. ERA5 uses 37, of which 29 would be within this model's domain (the model top is at 50 hPa, so nothing above it can be produced). Going to 29 levels would take the hourly file from ~0.8 GB to ~1.45 GB and a year of archive from 7.0 to 18.1 TB; on those grounds we kept 13. Say so now if the denser set matters for your use.